

iOS update

Apple releases iOS 4.3.2 update to solve 3G connectivity problems with iPhone 4

3 billion!

Google claims that more than 3 billion apps have been installed on Android globally

White iPhone?

Apple confirms that the long awaited white iPhone 4 will arrive this spring

sized 1GHz processor, much more RAM, a better screen resolution and the ability to playback HD videos.

Actually, today, almost every tablet claims to be able to record 720p HD videos and playback HD videos without any stutter. We're headed into another stalemate with hardware becoming standard across the board again. Apps sell tablets, not UIs and hardware.

A CIVIL WAR

Apps maketh the tablet

We're used to complaining about the way Apple manhandles its developers, and has rigid quality checks before allowing an app to be published on the Apple Store. We've also praised Android and its adopters for welcoming with open arms any app submissions. BlackBerry and Symbian are following suite too. Although app numbers on the other stores may have jumped significantly, Apple is not too worried, thanks to the fact that their apps all work flawlessly.

FUTURE WEAPONS

What will be different?

Currently, there are five different operating systems at play in the tablet ecosystem. The OS are – Apple iOS; Google Android; RIM QNX Playbook OS; HP WebOS; Microsoft Windows 7

While Apple has tasted success immediately in the tablet market, Android has gotten off to a steady start as well, albeit helped by the sheer variety of the products based on Android, compared to just one from Apple. However, Android still shows some rough edges. This is what we think will happen in 2011.

- Android's "made for the tablet" 3.0 version will take tablets into a completely different league altogether. The interface tweaks, media playback capabilities, support for faster hardware and the clamp-

down on the ability of the hardware manufacturers to "over-customize" it will mean that the OS from Google's stable will be more streamlined (and optimised) than ever before. Will that mean a better experience for the end user? Maybe, maybe not. Too much customisation add features and enhances usability of the entire Android package, but Google's attempt to iron out the un-optimized modifications may result in hardware manufacturers not bothering at all.

- Even though Android 3.0 has been received with a lot of oohs and aahs (from the videos we have seen), Google knows that it needs to raise the bar higher. Apparently, Google is working on a tablet version of the Chrome OS. Expect it before the end of the year.
- RIM's Playbook tablet is aimed as much at the end consumer as it is targeted at the corporates and business users. The attempt is to make the entire office experience available to the user on an even bigger screen, with the fun capabilities (media playback prowess and even games) to boot. A complete tablet? Not really, but will be the tablet for the business user, to complement the BlackBerry smartphone. QNX is the OS installed in this tablet. RIM is attempting to handle the app issue by making this compatible with Android apps. If that doesn't work, QNX will need to have Plan B to fall back on.
- HP is using the WebOS to

challenge Android. However, this is the same OS that could not save Palm's smartphone business. Hard to imagine it successfully challenging Android and iOS, straightaway. However, HP realises the importance of this, and it is the one shot that'll make or break their tablet. HP has trashed a lot of WebOS updates, the way we trash a sheet full of rough calculations or notes. The work on improving the webOS continues with no compromises, and for the sake of competition, we hope it works.

- Microsoft's tablet plans. This is one riddle almost no one has been able to figure out. While some Windows 7 based tablets have been released, powered by Intel's Atom processor, it is essentially a desktop OS behaving like a desktop OS, inside a tablet. Compared to the slickness of the rivals, this one is a lumbering giant. Do not expect any dedicated OS for the tablet in 2011. However, what surprises us is the fact that Microsoft hasn't thought about putting Windows Phone 7 OS on tablets. It worked for Android, after all. Expect this to dawn upon them, sooner or later.
- Apple iPad 3? Isn't that the inevitable question! Not likely, we say. Apple will let the iPad 2 get all the accolades till at least the beginning of next year. And that will complete the one-year life cycle of the iPad 2, anyway. **[1]**



The BlackBerry Playbook